

‘Disruption can be turned into an opportunity’

Puneet Chhatwal, MD & CEO of IHCL, that runs the Taj group of hotels, explains why it is important for hotels to be present across segments in India, his company’s plans and more

PHOTOS BY MANDAR DEODHAR

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A visit to the Presidential Suite at the Taj Mahal Palace hotel in Mumbai is an overwhelming experience. It is very large, luxurious and has had an impressive guest list. Surprisingly, it is the first time that Puneet Chhatwal, MD & CEO of The Indian Hotels Company Ltd (IHCL)—that runs the Taj group of hotels—is here. It is an indication of how busy the man, who joined as IHCL’s big boss in November 2017, is as travel takes away most of his time. Now, he is as busy as ever with new hotel openings and innovative product offerings. Chhatwal, who has spent more than 40 years in the space, explains why he is optimistic about India in an interview with *Business Today’s* Sourav Majumdar and Krishna Gopalan. Edited excerpts:

Q: Can you tell us about IHCL’s transition from hotels to a bigger play in hospitality?

A: We were always in hospitality. The concept of a

flight kitchen is not new, nor is Vivanta. Some additions to our portfolio are SeleQtions [signature hotels and resorts], home stays [amā Stays & Trails] and home delivery [Qmin].

In India, I would like to think the concept of hospitality was focussed on just a service. It was important that we had a good look at the business. I had the advantage of working overseas for many years... [and] saw from close quarters the success of Ibis for instance [in France] or Premier Inn in the UK. Premier Inn has over 5,000 hotels in this category [a limited service chain]. What’s the limit for that in India?

I started my career with flight kitchens. Today, TajSats has 58 per cent market share of all domestic meals. Those kitchens can be used as cloud kitchens as well... [it is an] untapped opportunity. Taj is not just our brand, but the crown jewel of this nation. This is everybody’s Taj. It is very special.

When I joined, we went for a multi-brand strategy and created the largest hospitality ecosystem... We embarked on a journey of growth—gain not just in the number of rooms, but growth in revenue and margins—and we succeeded for nine consecutive quarters. Then came Covid-19 and lockdowns. The last four quarters have been phenomenal and the outlook going ahead looks good.

Q: The Covid-19 pandemic has been a tough time for all. How did it make IHCL more resilient in the midst of a very challenging business environment?

A: There is a fundamental human need for business and leisure and you cannot take that away. That is a huge plus working in our favour. However, in India, the landscape is not easy since connectivity is a challenge... Often, planning travel in India is difficult because of air connectivity. Over time, good infrastruc-